

Xeriscapes – Drought-Friendly Landscapes

By: Chaz Wilke - Staff Writer



As California faces its worst drought in the past 850 years (<http://usat.ly/1y9NxJi>), homeowners are left juggling statewide water restrictions with homeowner association lawn care requirements (<http://cbsloc.al/1qrRgO3>). What are environmentally conscious homeowners to do? The answer might be found in a term that the average homeowner might have never heard: Xeriscaping.

Xeriscaping is the process of using regionally indigenous flora and land coverings to landscape your yard. The term xeriscape in part refers to the reduced or eliminated need for additional water needed to sustain the plants. This means a significant savings of water and money.

Perhaps long ago there was an effort to make the common Los Angeles yard a nostalgic trip back to those found in Europe thousands of miles away. Needless to say, as California lumbers towards another winter that meteorologists predict (<http://usat.ly/1tECtDc>), may not bring enough rainfall, something needs to change.

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A Changing Climate Changes the Landscape

If the climate statistics aren't stirring enough, consider this: The iconic symbol of Southern California, the palm tree, is largely not native to this region. All types of palm trees, including the California-indigenous *Washingtonia Filifera* have been transplanted in the Southland. The 60-foot-tall indigenous palms actually come from the valleys of the Colorado Desert.

"Thousands of the city's most visible palms were planted early in the 20th century as the city took shape and later in preparation for the 1932 Olympics," says USA Today reporter William M. Welch. In fact, many of the palm trees lining the streets of the Crenshaw district are all relics of the 1932 Los Angeles hosted Olympics.

"It's a Hollywood postcard sort of thing," says Betsey Landis, author of *Southern California Native Plants for School Gardens*. "It's not native (<http://usat.ly/1x9WaUT>). We're a Mediterranean climate, and it's a desert plant. But then everything grows in Southern California."

Or at least everything used to be able to grow in this climate. When water was abundant the endless sun of SoCal helped keep everything alive and growing. Now, the burden is on the homeowner to make up for the lack of natural rainfall.

"[Palm trees] need an abundance of water in the soil to grow successfully, and so they—like the manicured lawns they often adorn—rely on the vast amounts of water that Southern California imports from distant watersheds," says Nathan Masters of KCET (<http://bit.ly/13NvgIU>).

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Coming to Terms

For well over a century, Southern California homeowners have been living a lie. We, the people of SoCal, have built homes and landscapes designed for cooler, wetter climates. The drought that's continuing through 2014 shows that landscaping methodology is in direct contrast with this region's climate. We live in a desert. The climate of Southern California is closer to the Mediterranean than the rain-soaked English countryside. So why do we keep attempting to shoehorn broad green lawns into our yards while we have a massive array of indigenous flora to choose from?

Well, feel the breeze because the winds of change have arrived and xeriscaping is quickly gaining popularity.

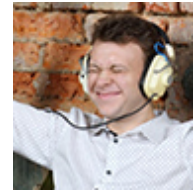
Homeowners now have a water-saving choice over traditional lawns in the arid regions of America. Perhaps part of the reason xeriscaping is catching on is due to the fact that some municipalities offer rebates for homeowners who dig up water-hungry lawns. SoCalWaterSmart.com provides an overview on how to prepare and submit your application for [a turf removal rebate](http://bit.ly/1qrRRPW) (<http://bit.ly/1qrRRPW>) of up to \$2 per square foot from participating municipalities.

Often, rebate program personnel will first evaluate your lawn to establish that you are eligible to participate. That might help reassure some homeowners who worry that once they tear up their turf they'll get the bad news that they don't qualify for a rebate. Check with your local municipality to see what rebates are offered in your area. Usually, applicants must supply before and after photos of their lawns. Each municipality is different, so be sure to check with yours before starting your landscaping project.



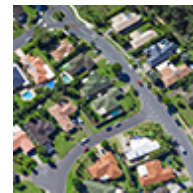
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Saving and Adapting

Saving water and money comes at the cost. It could mean revising your vision of a large manicured lawn and replacing it with winding paths lined by beds of succulents and desert flowers.

Xeriscaping your yard doesn't mean you will diminish the beauty or color of your home's plants. Desert plants come in just as many vibrant colors as those found in wetter climates. You will most likely need to say goodbye to a yard carpeted end to end in grass. Deserts have grass, but it tends to be sparse and ornamental. Yet, the number of flowers, shrubs and trees available in a desert climate may surprise you. Eartheasy.com provides a list (<http://bit.ly/1vPG8wk>) of native plants a homeowner can choose from when planning a xeriscaped yard.

As landscapingla.com demonstrates, xeriscaping results can be stunning (<http://bit.ly/1Gu3TIY>). Aside from the yearly savings and potential rebates, a xeriscaped lawn fits right in with the Southern California landscape and is bound to grow with less daily cultivation.

Takeaway

Xeriscaping is a great choice for savvy homeowners looking to conserve money, time, and water. Yards adorned with indigenous flora can be left nearly untended and should continue to grow and look beautiful during the drought. The benefits of this new trend in landscaping are nearly too many to list, but it is important to remember that xeriscaping is not currently mandatory. This is why many municipalities have rebate systems in place to incentivize the switch.

If you wish to keep your turf-covered yard in Los Angeles, you may absolutely do so. However, the cost, amount of maintenance and quantity of water required to keep up a yard of grass can be daunting. Large yards of green grass have long been a symbol of wealth. But, perhaps moving forward they may also become a sign of indifference to the greater civic good of your Los Angeles neighbors.

We don't know how much rain we'll get this winter, but experts are speculating about [rationing water \(http://bit.ly/1qrSBEG\)](http://bit.ly/1qrSBEG) in the Southland as soon as next summer. With that grim possibility in our near future, responsible action is a must. It would be tragic if Angelinos should have to decide between watering the grass and quenching their thirst.

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